

The Female Trickster—Known as *Trickstar*— As Exemplified by Two American Legendary Women, “Billy” Tipton and Mother Jones

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Tricks are always engaging even when they are dangerous or imminently harmful. Their performance invites wonder, raises curiosity, and frequently encourages a desire to explore the rationale for the trick, its ramifications, what it can accomplish or access. Often we admire the trickster, are in awe of *him* (tricksterism is traditionally regarded as a male activity), but we can just as readily be suspicious of him and feel threatened by tactics that, after all, depend upon some form of disguise and cunning, as well as a beguiling charm. Because the trickster is so frequently irresistible, we can be easily caught in the trick and convinced to think and act in ways that are disadvantageous to our own interests. Tricksters, however, are complex figures; while they may be malicious and unscrupulous, they may also be beneficent, their “tricks” motivated and devised to expose wrongdoing and, ultimately, responsible for bringing about a more humane condition, a more humane society. In fact, the trick is generally used to facilitate an action only because the action cannot be achieved through more direct means; that is, the trickster may be oppressed or subject to limitations, prejudices, controls that prevent him or *her* from initiating efforts that are necessary for his or her own freedom or others’ liberation. Of course, women have most often had to use both wit and “wiles” to achieve individual autonomy, if not use some form of strategy merely to survive.

The trickster is an important figure in mythology; recognizing his personal traits and the patterns of his action conveys a more distinct awareness of how we may perceive more modern or “popular” tricksters and, also, understand the types of tricks they perform. In the anthropological literature, the trickster dupes and deceives in order to satisfy his needs for food and sex or to prop up his ego by aggrandizement, assault and appropriation. Witness Coyote, that famous North American trickster, or regard the exploits of the Winnebago Trickster as described by Paul Radin in his classic study, *The Trickster: A Study in American*

Indian Mythology, 1956 (the cycle of tricks is related in Part One). If we are to believe in the “cycle” of tales (that is, a distinctly formulated sequence of narrative), then we realize that Wakdjunkago, the Winnebago Trickster, gradually becomes socialized (Radin, *World* 313). He evolves from the infantile, mostly atomized self, who demands instant physical gratification, to the mature, self-restrained, socially conscious human being. In the classical mythology with which we are more familiar, Hermes is the child figure who both plays and plunders; but he is also an artist and inventor and becomes both healer and peacemaker (Doty 56-64). Prometheus is, of course, the trickster *sine qua non*, the culture bringer, the rebel against unjust authority, represented by Zeus, and the deliverer of humankind. Yet, Athene is also a trickster—or a *trickstar* as I call female tricksters—and while she does not introduce so important an element as fire into human existence, she does invent the plough and the system of numbers and generally encourages reason and reflection over ill-considered action. There are other trickstars: in the anthropological literature, Nafigi, the Amazon heroine of the Kapolo tribe (Basso 216-17); in Egyptian mythology, Isis; in Zuni mythology, “The Rabbit Huntress.” In Greek mythology, we may also consider Hera, Pandora and Circe—all different for the types of tricks they initiate and for the impact of those tricks on others.

More significantly, trickstars inhabit the folkloric rather than the mythical landscape; their presence is wide-ranging. They appear in tales from all over the world, and their activities are various, their accomplishments generally positive. It is in the folkloric tradition that Billy Tipton and Mother (Mary Harris) Jones can be recognized as trickstars; for in their resistance to social conditions and in their abilities to manipulate conventions and power structures, they achieve a personal expression, advance their own agendas and, in very different ways, transform the way we think and relate to others. In addition, Mother

Jones actively transformed the lives of others and influenced economic and political thought. In their trickstar capacities, both women show us how folktales and cultures intersect; the actions of Billy Tipton and Mother Jones may be more distinctly understood by referring to folktale analogues. The folktale heroines, in turn, recognize, in a wider sense, the tactics used by these two culture figures: Billy Tipton in assuming a male disguise in order to advance a musical career, Mother Jones appearing as genteel female reformer in raising consciousness and rousing the public to the plight of exploited workers and child laborers. In the spirit of the folktale trickstar, each woman defies gender roles, rebels against establishment ideas. Both the entertainer and the social activist refuse boundaries imposed by others who want to retain the power structure. They "rescue" their own lives, and Mother Jones rescues, or attempts to rescue, the lives of others. Each consistently pursues an idea or set of ideas, hopes to achieve a meaningful objective and desires to become empowered in order to realize her ends. Both women in their trickstar capacities challenge their societies and, to some extent, transform the lives and minds of others.

The nature of the trickster has both baffled and intrigued anthropologists, psychiatrists, literary critics and scholars in fields such as history, sociology, theology, as well as folklore. Most agree that the trickster figure is ambiguous, incorporates contrarities, is "on the boundary" of society and serves to mediate oppositions, bring together those elements which have always been at odds. Trickster is, according to Radin, both "divine culture hero and divine buffoon" (Radin, *Trickster* 125). William Hynes and William Doty see in the trickster "conflations of selfishness and buffoonery, of cleverness and heroic activity" (23). Mythical tricksters, like Legba, the culture hero of Dahomey, is a rebel against social custom, "the master of sexuality," and a talented manipulator of language (Pelton 119). Trickster is also a master of deceit in the use of body camouflage and in the way the character conceals, entices, and appropriates (Young 195-96). Body camouflage is often equivalent to the trickster taking on the form of the other gender, and tricksters are disposed to be androgynous (Babcock-Abrahams 159). Consolidating male power and female perception is the means by which the folktale trickstar changes society—both for Billy Tipton and Mother Jones.

As popular trickstars, both women may also be more clearly realized by noting other traits of Trickster, these same traits characterizing the folktale trickstar. Paradoxically, even while Trickster falsifies

or distorts, he is essentially a truth-teller. Witness Ananse, the Ashanti trickster figure (Pelton 24). Marginality is another singular trait that defines Trickster; for Trickster is "in between time and culture" (Babcock-Abrahams 149). Of course, both for her sex and gender, the female has "naturally" been regarded as marginal; thus, the trickstar is twice-born in the capacity for tricking. As that marginal individual violating custom, law and nature, Trickster becomes the source of laughter. That laughter liberates as it defies and releases the Trickster to ridicule status and hierarchy, the hypocrisies of the "civilized." Clearly, the woman has always had reason to address issues of inequity; and laughter has often given her the strength to encounter or trespass barriers. As Trickstar she has often played the fool to shape-shift reality and expose the real foolishness of human institutions.

The trickstar in folktales raises consciousness about the male dominated hierarchy whether she is merely a diverting character, a jester; a more reprehensible character, such as a betrayer or thief; or merely a facilitating individual. Mostly, she is distinctly beneficial, a challenger of prevailing conditions and a creator of more ideal means of human interaction and relationship. At the same time, she finds a means of gaining control over her own life, a means of finding a significant role. Both Billy Tipton and Mother Jones demonstrate these trickstar qualities and abilities.

"Billy" or Dorothy Tipton (1914-1989) is, as a trickstar, a master deceiver, one who appropriated another gender and successfully carried out the masquerade for almost fifty years, duping not only the audience she entertained, but also the five women—or "wives" with whom she lived over a succession of years. Initially she "became" male in order to advance as a jazz musician, as well as to achieve financial independence. Beginning as what she regarded as a necessary strategy, the shape-shifting became permanent. To make it in a "man's world," she had to remain a man; praxis moved into nexus, and perhaps she discovered *he* was more identical to who she actually was. As a man, not only was she able to find employment as a musician, but as that masculinity, and the power it carried, became permanent to her everyday existence, she assumed other roles—she directed her own trio, planned their tours, negotiated contracts. She tested the limits of her musicianship; and not only was *he* a pianist, saxophonist and singer, but *he* also performed as a comedian and wrote his own material. In that male persona, she formed committed relationships with four women, all of whom treated *him* with loving care; Kitty Kelly, with whom

he lived from 1962 to 1980, actually became his legal wife, and they adopted three sons.

When, one day in 1989, Billy could not be roused, the youngest of these sons, William, called an ambulance. After the medics came, they proceeded to loosen Billy's shirt in order to resuscitate him; and it is only when his "*father*" is dead, that William discovers his father's true sex; and the public, including his former wife, realizes the amazing hoax. Billy Tipton challenges our ideas about gender and sex; posits the question of whether gender is an artificial construct, and asks to what extent sexuality depends on our identification of gender. Dorothy posing as Billy and remaining Billy temporarily or permanently is also a theme in folktales.

Trickstars in folktales often disguise themselves as males in order to escape from dangerous circumstances or the confining identities they suffer for being female. In some instances, they cross-dress to seek greater freedom or to obtain unusual power. In a Mohawk tale, "Coyote Learns a New Trick" (Brant 31-35), the heroine dresses up as a male only to have "a good joke." The joke turns out to be on her; for the heroine discovers that she is really a lesbian. Finally, she decides to celebrate this new identity. Another tale from Rumania, "The Girl Who Pretended to Be a Boy" (Hearn 121-43) relates how a daughter, in order to save her father's life, must assume the position of soldier. In that disguise "he" is desired by a beautiful woman. Then as the result of an auspicious curse, the soldier actually turns into a biological male. Happily transformed, he not only marries the adoring woman, but is clear to assert *his* power over her.

Two other tales discuss a less permanent male persona as initiated by the heroines of these narratives. In a Russian tale, "The Lute Player" (Barchers 241-44), the wife posing as a male musician so entrances the king with *his* music that the musician is able to succeed in releasing her husband from the king's prison. Of course, the male disguise is a temporary expedient. Nonetheless, the woman demonstrates that she has rare musical abilities; it is the male disguise that enables her to perform. Another heroine, The Pirate Princess, in the Eastern European tale named after her (Schwartz 237-45), also poses as male while she continues to retain her sex. In male disguise, assisted by other young women in male dress, the heroine braves the dangers of pirates and eventually arrives in a foreign land where she/he becomes king and is honored for "*his*" wisdom. Eventually the new "king" confesses her real sex to those she governs and relinquishes her throne to her long-lost lover.

Like Billy Tipton, all of these folktale trickstars are clever and wily, supremely adaptable, as well as articulate and good humored. Billy had to be remarkably inventive to conceal his gender from those musicians with whom he performed on a regular basis, not to speak of the strategies he needed to use with the several women who shared his bed! Many of Billy's routines relied on humor, often sexual jokes which hinted at his double life. He even played female roles—that is, he *double* cross-dressed, an outrageous masquerade which showed cunning and bravado, as well as a wild kind of mischief. In one act, Billy has the straight man ask, "How many sexes are there?" Tipton responds, "Three. The male sex, the female sex and the insects" (Middlebrook 49). His joke is on "himself" and on all of us who are so certain and so credible and so easily duped by labels and conventional expectation. Dorothy Billy Tipton is jester, challenger, rebel, and transformer.

Certainly, all these attributes of the trickstar—and more—are expressed in the person and life of Mary Harris "Mother" Jones (1830-1930). With a facile tongue, an acute intelligence, a courage undaunted by obvious and present danger, Mother Jones' triumph, unlike Billy's, was not in rescuing herself (though in some sense she may have achieved this), but in rescuing others from oppressive circumstances. Furthermore, she pursued the difficult course of changing people's entrenched beliefs, of transforming ideas about work and ownership and the sharing of rights and privileges. She opposed tyranny in several forms, championed Mexican liberation and sought justice for all laboring peoples, including the children whose childhoods perished in factories and mines. She is our American culture heroine and recognized by such notable people as Carl Sandburg, Eugene Debs and Clarence Darrow.

With her gift for language and her genius for quick retort, especially to those whose words were seldom questioned, Mother Jones resembles "The Clever Peasant Girl" tale type (875 in the Stith Thompson *Motif-Index of Folk-Literature*). In the many variants of this type, the girl demonstrates how verbal facility and logical reasoning can triumph over otherwise intransigent power. In several versions of the tale, the peasant girl actively questions the policy of absolute rule; ultimately her ability to offer fair judgment is respected, and she is selected to make pronouncements in the courtroom.

While the heroine makes possible the acknowledgment of dissidence as an improving force, she is never shrill or obvious. Rather, she is always good-humored and charming, selecting her appeals, in this

instance, to her husband, with scrupulous care. In the same way, Mother Jones chooses tactics that will move mine operators, sheriffs, judges and all those whose power must yield if conditions are to improve for the laboring classes. Though Mother Jones can be raucous and “in your face” with miners, scrappy and uncompromising in what she proposes they do, that voice and that manner shifts for the “big bosses”—she is then the refined, decorous, soft-spoken “mother” everyone adores.

In another sense, Mother Jones is Gulnara, the Tartar Woman, the heroine from the tale by the same name (Riordan 20-26). Gulnara is the shrewd and fierce and courageous woman of right conviction who volunteers to serve for her father in the khan’s army. A brilliant military strategist, she succeeds in defeating the khan’s enemy, only to discover that the khan is untrustworthy, corrupt and murderous. Gulnara averts death by sending the khan and his leaders into the same fatal trap they had planned for her. When she returns to her own country, she vows to the citizens that they will no longer serve any despot, will have no taxes to pay, will not serve in an army to empower an unjust leader.

Though, during some labor conflicts, Mother Jones advised miners to arm, she preferred a peaceful means of resolving disputes. Aicha, the protagonist in “The Wise Woman,” an Algerian tale (Barchers 323-24), defeats the army besieging her village by persuading the village officials to play a trick on the invaders. Later, when the enemy force finds a calf grazing in the village pasture, they are worried; for they had concluded that the village was entirely decimated by hunger. The army officials are still more amazed and more worried when after they butcher the calf, they find corn in the animal’s stomach. Surmising that the villagers are actually thriving, are a formidable threat, the enemy force retreats, and the village returns to peace. Aicha is honored by her people. Great tribute is also given to Mother Jones for her success in unionizing workers and securing improved conditions.

Another folktale heroine resembles Mother Jones both for her respect for the laboring classes and for her determination to educate the people about the exploitation of laborers by those who are often paid honor and respect. Anait, the titled heroine of this Russian-Armenian tale (Zheleznova 134-47), succeeds though her wits and her determination to save others from tyranny and injustice. After her husband is captured and enslaved in an underground dungeon, where men are worked to their deaths, she dresses in male clothing and leads a march to rescue her husband and

the other workers. She also exposes the head priest as the villain who secretly profited from the immoral and criminal use of these laborers. For the first time, the townspeople recognize that they have not been attentive to conditions around them, and realize that they must take cooperative responsibility for protecting their own lives and the lives of others.

Another character in folk narrative who gives us a special awareness of Mother Jones’ character and activities is the youngest daughter of a Sufi king. She appears in the tale entitled “The Wayward Princess” (Shah 63-65) as a determined woman who will not be imposed on by authority, even the authority of her own father. Rather, she chooses the hardship of exile; yet in that wilderness, and to the wonder of all those who had scorned her, she creates a beautiful city. This transformed wilderness becomes a refuge for outcasts and eccentrics, and these individuals she encourages to seek wisdom and peace. While Mother Jones does not transform industrial America into a Utopia, she does seek a socio-economic ideal, calls for collective ownership of industry and constantly strives to improve conditions for workers. Like the Sufi princess in the tale, she experienced “exile” from the larger society; and also like her, she helped transform the economic “wilderness” into a more civilized, more hopeful landscape.

How is Mother Jones a trickstar? Like all tricksters, both male and female, Mother Jones was a marginal figure—marginal in class and marginal in behavior. She acted in ways considered inappropriate for her gender; and she refused to give automatic reverence to those in authority, refused to comply with orders she felt were stupid or unjust, refused codes and conventions when they interfered with truth or right. Yet, while Prisilla Long remarks on her unconventional and unladylike behavior, she also acknowledges a meaningful contradiction. Speaking of Mother Jones, Long asserts:

The way she lived...was not patterned after the expected behavior of a good woman. Her drinking, swearing, traveling, her periodic sojourns in jail, her physical bravado, her labor career itself, called up no feminine ideal. Yet, as a powerful symbol to great masses of workers, she represented the most womanly quality of her day (11).

That “womanly quality” tilted the marginal element in strange and calculated directions which enabled Mother Jones to find favor not only with the laboring class, but with the very people she criticized and opposed. For who could be angry or feel seriously threatened by a stout, elderly lady in a black dress and

ribboned hat, flouncy lace at her chin and white as the filmy hair softly framing her face? Certainly, Mary Jones pulled off the “mother” role superbly. It is interesting, in this connection, that in the early decades of the twentieth century, “Motherhood was used to justify a multitude of extrafamilial activities (Ryan 225). Jane Addams, for example, alluded to settlement work as “the great mother breast of our common humanity,” (225) and the suffrage movement justified its cause by citing the infantile helplessness of a populace who needed to be protected by “the mother of the race” (226). Mother Jones became that pervasive image; the miners and steelworkers were her “boys,” never mind that she was as tough as they were, if not tougher.

Certainly, like all trickstars, Mother Jones was ambiguous; and when an individual moves in seeming contrarities, her actions are difficult to anticipate; and when her image seems to give lie to her reputation and anticipated action, that individual easily has the upper hand. Who else but Mother Jones could face down machine guns directly aimed at her, at the same time chastising the militia men in West Virginia who attempted to stop her in her tracks? She often puzzled the power structure more than she inflamed it—and that was the strategy she counted on. If you become a riddle, people will be sidetracked in the attempt to solve *you*; meanwhile, you can stealthily undermine the power structure and continue to espouse your radical theories. To the miners Mother Jones was feisty, challenging, “spoiling for a fight and spilling over with contempt for the moneyed, powerful classes” (Fetherling 104). With journalists and members of the oligarchy she was conciliatory, gracious and reasonable, could even appear folksy, take the pose of the old-fashioned schoolmarm (Fetherling 106). Mother Jones geared her presence, her manner and her voice to accomplish distinct economic and social objectives.

Her tricks, which mingled the comedic with the serious, were devised to assure the success of these objectives. In 1899, in Arnot, Pennsylvania, she armed strikers’ wives with pots and pans, mops and brooms to frighten away mules, so that coal cars and their scab drivers would not be able to return from the mines (Fetherling 39). During the anthracite mine strike of 1900, Mother Jones organized women to use diversionary tactics so as to draw attention from the sheriff, his deputies and the general manager of the Lattimore mine and away from the 3,000 strikers silently gathered to detain the arrival of the morning shift (Long 14-15). Furthermore, in this same effort, in order to assure compliance of the miners to the strike order, women were posted at the mine to grab any miner who insisted on working; the outnumbered

man would be forcibly carried to his wife or mother (Jones 85-86). When during a coal strike in Westmoreland County, Pennsylvania, in 1910, women were arrested for disturbing the peace, Mother Jones, part of their group, counseled them to bring their babies into the prison. For all the disturbance the women cause in the jail, singing and, also, trying to assuage their crying babies, their thirty-day sentence was reduced to that one night (Long 15-16). The prison authorities were happy to see them leave.

In 1903 Mother Jones organized and led a Children’s Crusade to convince President Theodore Roosevelt of the need for child labor laws. While the publicized destination of the marchers was Roosevelt’s home in Oyster Bay, Long Island, Mother Jones told *New York Tribune* reporters that the visit was “only a joke.” For, she said, “sometimes it takes extraordinary means to attract ordinary interest” (Fetherling 50-51). During that march, Mother Jones continually challenged the system which deprives children of their right to be protected. En route to Long Island, Mother Jones was asked by a professor of Princeton to speak to his class. To demonstrate her principles, Mother Jones used for her model one of the marchers, a ten-year old boy, stooped and bent with unhealthy pallor. “Here’s a textbook on economics,” she declared. “He gets three dollars a week and his sister who is fourteen gets six dollars. They work in a carpet factory ten hours a day while the children of the rich are getting higher education” (Fetherling 51). The professor had not bargained for this type of “lesson.”

As far as sources exist (and most sources are sparse, unreliable or nonexistent), Mother Jones seems to have started her trickstar routines in 1900 when in order to observe conditions in the cotton mills, she lied about who she was and made false promises to the mill managers. The conditions for a woman’s being employed depended on her being able to assure that her children would also be workers at the mill. For that reason, in Cottondale, Alabama, and later in mills located in Georgia and South Carolina, Mother Jones alleged that she had a family who would follow her and also become workers at the mill. Meanwhile, before the lie could be detected, Mother Jones was able to examine the wretched and dangerous conditions under which children worked, observing children with mutilated limbs and stunted growth (Fetherling 20). During that same year of 1900, she rescued one mill family impossibly in debt, the father ill and dying. Borrowing a wagon, Mother Jones greased the axles for a soundless escape and led the family to a train she had secretly enlisted from some

railroad workers (21). Mother Jones used lies and deception only in order to assure the safety of workers, otherwise helpless and unable to defend themselves. She also deceived to expose the greater deceptions practiced by those in power and was, in feigned roles, able to secure the documentation needed to bring employers' abuses to public awareness and, ultimately, to secure better conditions for workers.

The one lie she is known to have told union members brought outcries of betrayal. In 1921 at a meeting of steel workers in Charleston, West Virginia, Mother Jones insisted that the miners disband, call off their proposed strike. It is thought that in order to protect the miners' lives from the enormous number of forces and arms gathered by the governor of that state, Mother Jones purposely deceived her cherished "boys." She claimed to the workers that President Harding had sent a telegram promising an investigation of the mines, that conditions would be changed without a strike being necessary. When the telegram was revealed as bogus, Mother Jones suffered contempt; some even called her a traitor. Fetherling believes her tactic actually prevented many casualties among the miners, even an all-out catastrophe (184-90).

Rescuer, pursuer, challenger, rebel, Mother Jones moved others certainly by the courage of her participation—as the woman warrior, Gulnara; by her ideals—as “the wayward princess” in the Sufi tale. She used deception—as does the Algerian heroine, Aicha—in order to bring peace, though as peace bringer, her image would be marred. Yet, what is equally impressive was Mother Jones' voice, her wit, her beguiling grace. She was “the little peasant girl” for her eloquence and her devastating sense of satire. But Mother Jones had her own scathing tongue. She shamed the Colorado miners: “If you are too cowardly to fight, there are enough women to come in and beat the hell out of you” (Foner 36). To the society women in Ohio, she said:

You wear your high collars to support your jaw and keep your befuddled brains from oozing out of your mouths. While this commercial cannibalism is reaching in the cradle; pulling children into the factory to be destroyed; you, who are doing all in the name of Christianity, you are at home nursing your poodle dogs. It's high time you got out and worked for humanity. (Foner 98)

We can best understand Mother Jones by viewing her as “Experience” parading as “Innocence”—the street-smart tough dressed up as the Hallmark grandma. She comprised the perfect “Marriage of Heaven and Hell” that brings salvation to those who

are moved to action for the common good. She, as well as Billy Tipton, move us as “sisters,” as human beings. They join the folktale heroines as trickstars; and we recognize through who they are and the tricks they perform, how culture can be significantly interpreted and understood through folkloric inquiry and analysis. Both the folktale trickstar and her cultural counterpart we acknowledge for their struggles, their persistence, their humor and their courage; and Mother Jones we particularly honor for her extraordinary sanity and compassion, her refusal to bail out of trouble or buy into the trickery of the establishment.

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*Theoretical discussions of the trickster, the categorical invention of *trickstar*, and detailed analyses relating to her appearances in tales and her accomplishments more generally can be discovered in this source.

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